Lady Tata also took the boys on many holidays. One that Ratan remembers vividly is a visit to England in 1948. After staying close to Hyde Park in London, she took them to Worthing for a week's holiday by the sea. They stayed at the Vern's Hotel and Ratan has pleasant memories of playing on a pebble beach and riding on paddle boats.

He remembers: 'She [Lady Tata] went to meet Queen Mary on that trip. She was all so excited to meet her friend again, and she was practising how to curtsey and so on. Then she went and met her, while my father took a suite at Dorchester Hotel.'

Lady Tata and Ratan shared a special bond that was many-hued. It encompassed elements of both a mother–son and father–son relationship. It grew in strength after Ratan's parents separated. Lady Tata made Ratan her constant companion, particularly when she went on social calls, especially to her relatives.

Ratan too enjoyed these visits immensely. He now says ruefully: 'I would like to go back [to those times], but it's all gone.' But his face lights up when recalling those moments. His most delightful memory is of a particular visit to one of the residences that one of Lady Tata's relatives owned in Malabar Hill. He would 'often' visit them with his grandmother when he was in middle school. He vividly recalls that one of the houses he would visit had a large fountain with at least half a dozen ducks in it. Fascinated, one day he cautiously tiptoed to the edge of the fountain and leaned in to get closer to the ducks, only to throw himself back reflexively when a large drake came straight for the flummoxed little boy. There was nothing Ratan could do but turn tail and flee.

Ratan recalls that Lady Tata had a 'tough ethical framework', which she would not deviate from, irrespective of consequences. She demanded the same unflinching commitment to high standards from him. He says unequivocally that he grew up with 'only' the 'vocabulary' of morality resounding in his impressionable mind.

Ratan is a very systematic man. He plans his daily routine, prepares a 'Things to Do' list meticulously and works out his schedule much in advance. He learnt these habits from his grandmother as well. She used to plan all her daily activities and would give instructions to all those involved in their execution ahead of time.

Ratan remembers her sending notes to her butler, informing him of the number of people visiting her and instructing that they be served 'chicken